

EA NEGATIVITY AND EA INTERPRETATION

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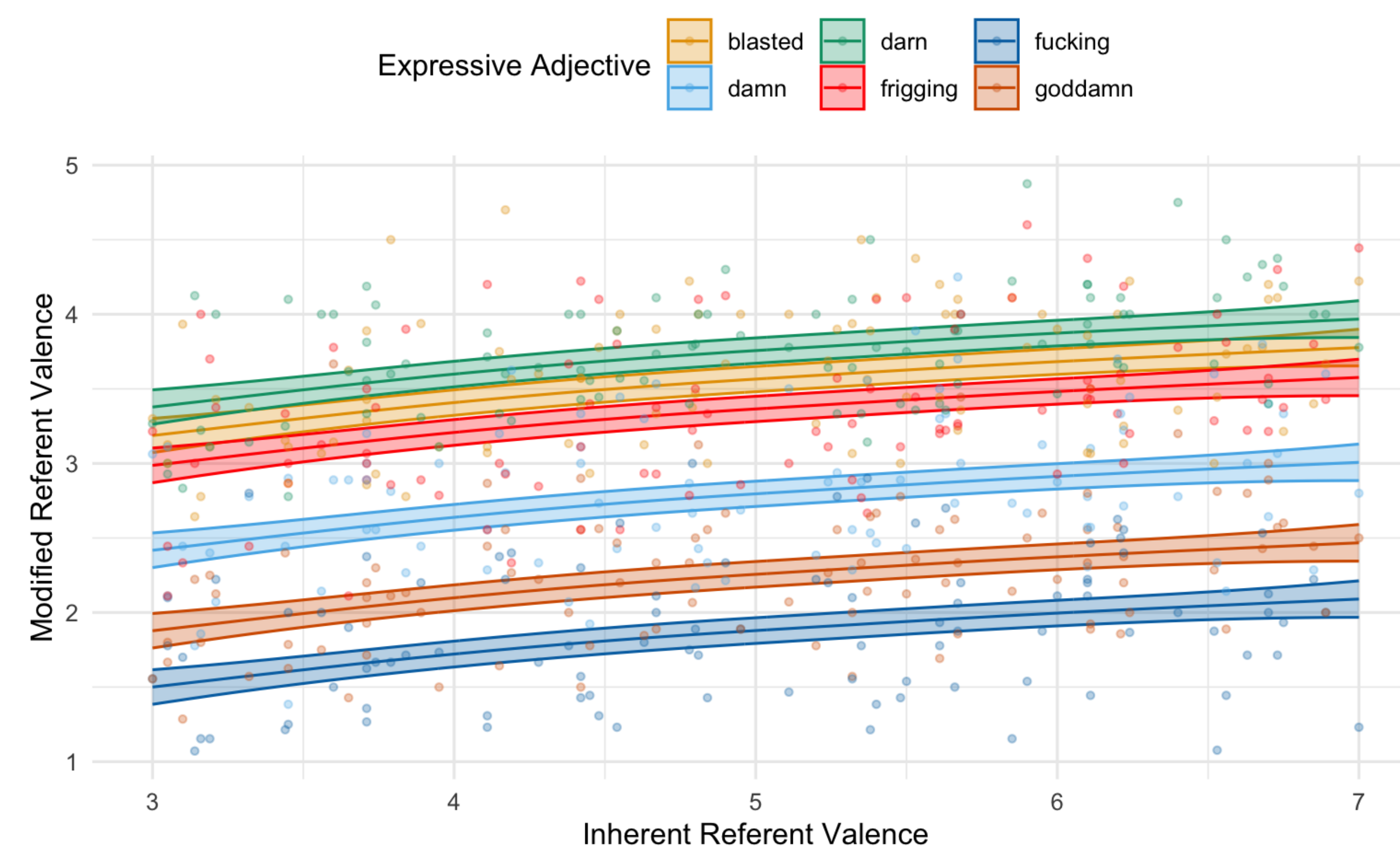
How does the negativity of expressive adjectives interact with the valence of discourse referents during interpretation?

Question: Do common expressive adjectives differ in how much negativity they express?

Design: 1×6 within-subjects rating study

Conditions: EA (*damn*, *darn*, *goddamn*, *fucking*, *frigging*, *blasted*)

Participants: $N = 78$ recruited via Prolific



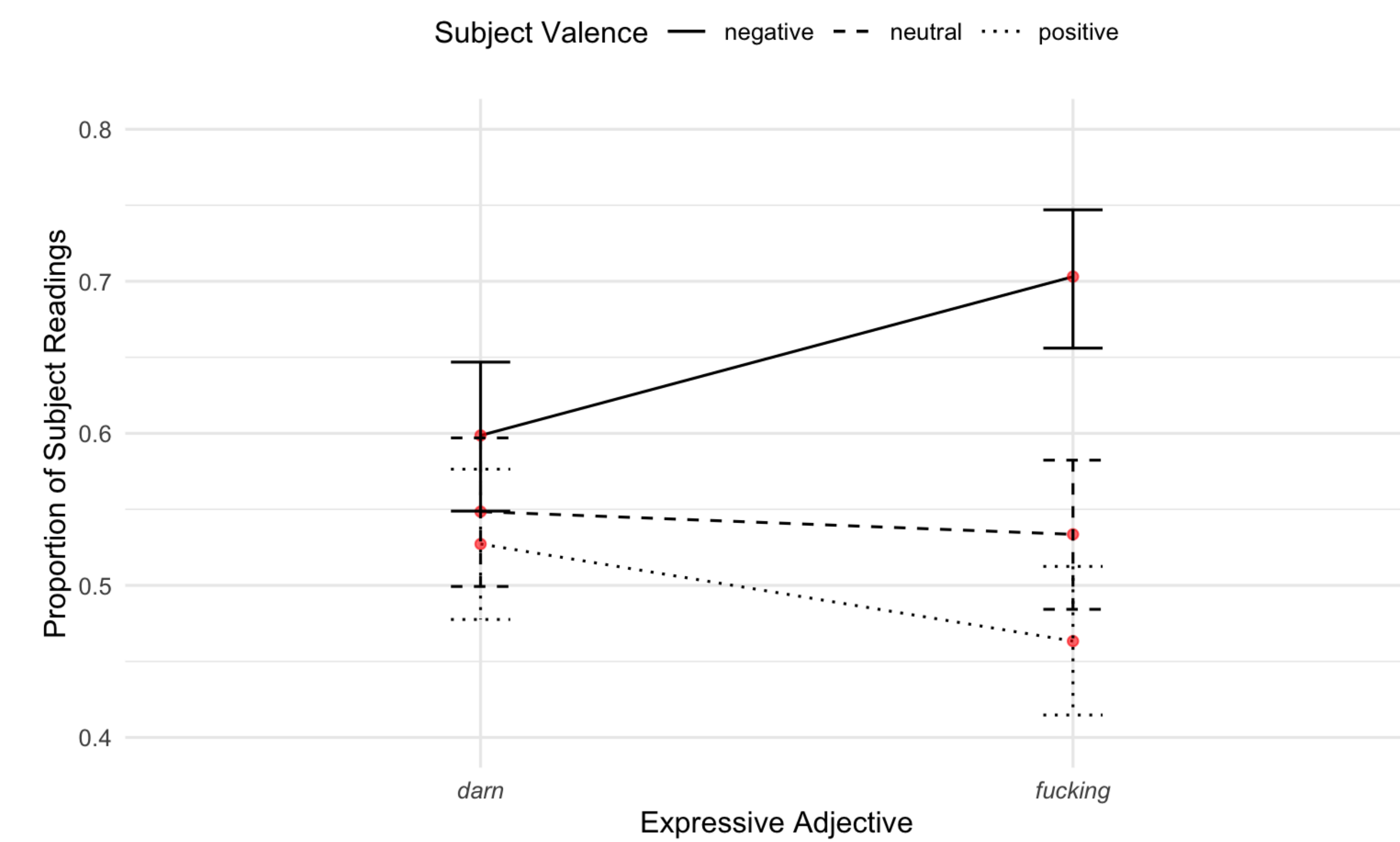
Take-home: *darn* is least negative and *fucking* most negative, yielding a clear negativity hierarchy across EAs.

Question: Are negative referents more likely EA targets, and does this depend on how negative the EA is?

Design: 2×3 within-subjects forced-choice study

Conditions: EA (*fucking* vs. *darn*) $\times$ subject valence (negative, neutral, positive)

Participants: $N = 80$ recruited via Prolific



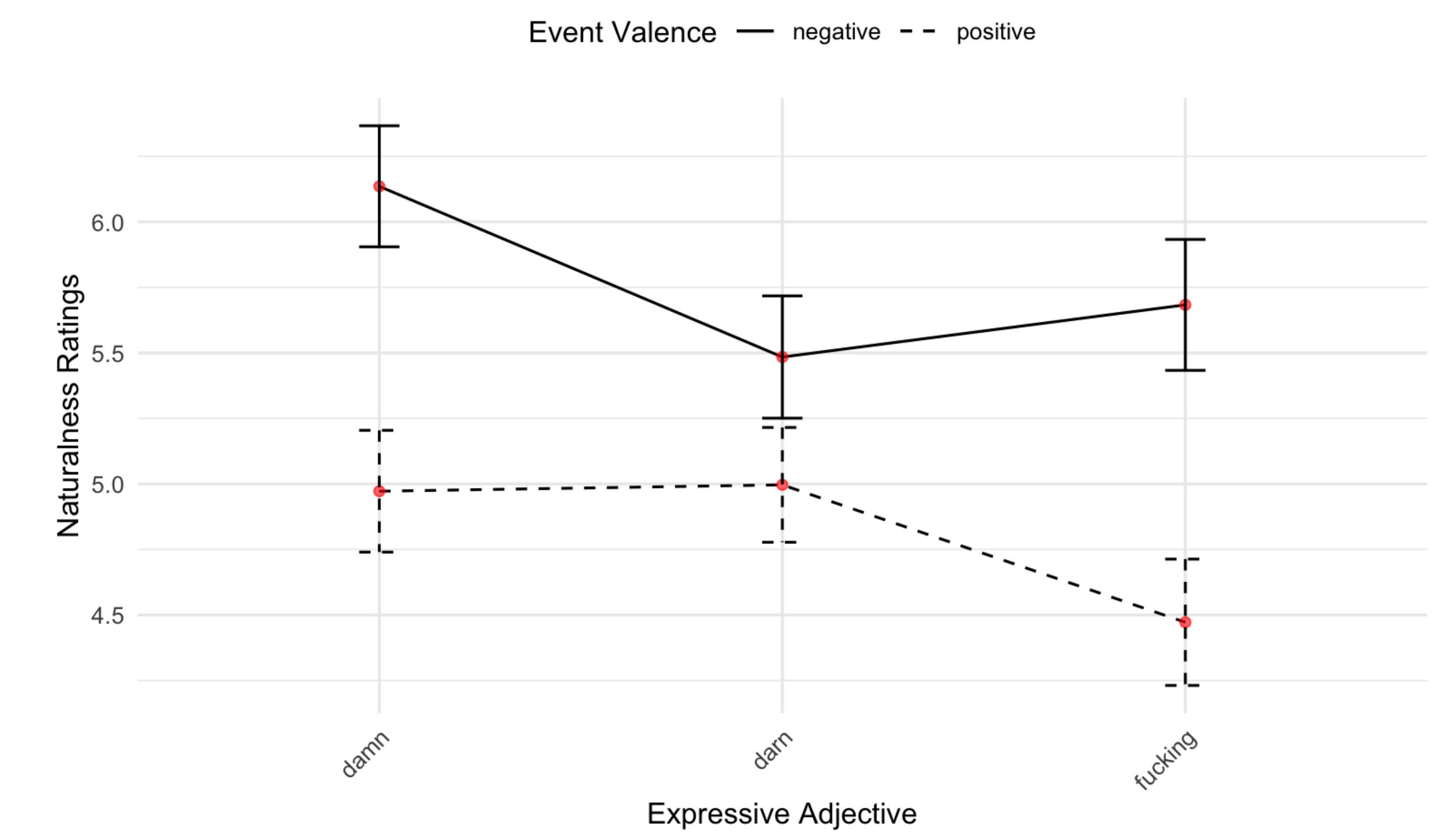
Take-home: Negative subjects attract more subject-readings, with the strongest effect for the highly negative EA *fucking*.

Question: Are strongly negative EAs less acceptable in contexts without a saliently negative referent?

Design: 3×2 within-subjects acceptability study

Conditions: EA (*darn*, *damn*, *fucking*) $\times$ event valence (positive, negative)

Participants: $N = 80$ recruited via Prolific



Take-home: Acceptability drops in positive contexts, especially for more negative EAs.

Expressive adjectives preferentially target negative referents, and this preference becomes stronger as the adjective itself becomes more negative.

Taken together, the three studies support a valence-based account of EA interpretation: EAs are not a homogeneous class, and both interpretation and acceptability depend on the match between EA negativity and referent valence.